

Preparing Your ADHD Tween for High School: Main Course Tips & Takeaways

How to Use This Guide

You don't need to do everything at once. In fact, please don't.

This guide is designed to help you build small, consistent habits that make daily life easier for your ADHD tween *and* for you.

Try this approach:

1. Start with one strategy. Choose something that feels doable this week — maybe it's a visual schedule or a short planning session.
2. Test it for two weeks. Notice what works, what doesn't, and how your child responds.
3. Tweak and adjust. Every ADHD brain is unique. Modify timing, visuals, or sensory supports to match your child's needs and interests.
4. Add gradually. Once one habit feels familiar, introduce another. Over time, these small shifts create meaningful change.

Remember — progress matters more than perfection. Each tiny improvement helps your child build independence, confidence, and regulation before high school begins.

Start Here: Regulation First

Before we talk about planners, routines, or time management, we start with regulation — because a regulated brain learns, listens, and connects better.

If you haven't already, read the free guide *Wired for Sensory: Understanding Your ADHD Tween's Unique Senses*. It helps you understand your child's sensory preferences and why supporting their nervous system comes first.

Once regulation is in place, these strategies become far easier to build and maintain.

Tip 1: Connection & Special Time

- Your relationship with your tween is the foundation for all other strategies.
- Prioritise five minutes of special, child-led time together daily.
- Connection builds emotional safety and resilience for the high school transition.

Tip 2: Visual Schedules & To-Do Lists

- Externalise routines and tasks using whiteboards, sticky notes, or visual lists.
- Try "task doubling" — pairing two tasks together to simplify routines and support working memory & sequencing skills.
- Encourage independence by reducing verbal reminders and increasing visual cues.

Tip 3: Consistent Routines

- Establish predictable morning, after-school, and evening routines.
- Use sensory cues (lamps, scents, or music) to signal transitions.
- Keep routines simple (maximum four steps) and flexible to your child's needs.

Tip 4: Weekly Planning

- Hold a short 15mins planning session each week (e.g., Sunday afternoon).
- Use a visual calendar for non-negotiables and flexible activities.
- Do midweek check-ins and adapt when needed.

Tip 5: Homework Blocks

- Begin with one or two short homework sessions each week (e.g., 25mins each).
- Build the habit of focused work in set blocks before high school begins. Even if this is dedicated reading time.
- Gradually increase duration as your child's stamina grows and homework demands increase

Tip 6: Clocks, Watches & Alarms

- Use analog clocks and visual timers to support time awareness.
- Encourage your tween to set their own alarms to build independence.
- Try "beat the clock" games for motivation, unless your child experiences time anxiety.

Tip 7: Setting Their Bedroom Up for Success

- Create clear zones: study, chill, and stuff.
- Use baskets, containers, and hooks to reduce clutter and make tidying easier.
- Teach small, repeatable systems like the "tub trick" for quick cleanups.

Tip 8: After-School Support

- Recognise that after-school is often the hardest time of day; meltdowns are common.
- Create a “landing zone” or sensory-friendly space for decompression.
- Co-create calming routines based on your child’s sensory needs.

Tip 9: Period Prep & Hormones

- Understand that hormonal shifts can heighten ADHD symptoms in girls.
- Prepare a discreet period pack for school and normalise conversations about changes.
- Track cycles together to build self-awareness and emotional literacy.

Tip 10: Movement & Nutrition

- Encourage daily movement your tween enjoys — dancing, swimming, walking the dog.
- Support regular meals and snacks with protein, complex carbs, and healthy fats.
- Consistency matters more than perfection — small habits compound.

Final Thoughts

- Progress, not perfection: Start with connection, focus on regulation, and build consistency one step at a time.
- Involve your tween in creating routines for better buy-in and independence.
- If things feel overwhelming, reach out to your GP or occupational therapist for extra support.
- This is an exciting stage of growth — your steady guidance helps their brain (and confidence) thrive.

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